

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Iran, Afghanistan, and Pakistan, asafoetida produces a gum obtained in summer from 4-year-old plants. The stems are cut off and successive slices are made through the roots. The gum wells up and is collected after it has hardened.

Part Used Oleo-gum-resin.

Constituents Asafoetida exudate contains 6–17% volatile oil, as well as resin and gum. The volatile oil contains disulphides (about 58%), which have an expectorant action. The oil also settles the digestion. Asafoetida resin contains sesquiterpenoid coumarins, including foetidin.

History & Folklore In the 4th century BCE, *Charaka Samhita*, a Hindu medical treatise, proclaimed asafoetida the best remedy for clearing gas and bloating. The name devil's dung notwithstanding, the plant is thought to have been the most popular spice in ancient Rome. Asafoetida is as persistent in aroma as garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59), and is still used as a flavoring.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In Middle Eastern and Indian herbal medicine, asafoetida is used for simple digestive problems such as gas, bloating, indigestion, and constipation. Asafoetida's volatile oil, like that of garlic, has components that leave the body via the respiratory system and aid the coughing up of congested mucus. Asafoetida is taken (usually in tablet form) for bronchitis, bronchial asthma, whooping cough, and other chest problems. Asafoetida also lowers blood pressure and thins the blood. The herb has a reputation for helping in neurotic states.

Related Species *F. silphion* was used in ancient Rome as a contraceptive. It was overharvested and died out in about 300 CE. *F. persica* is used in the Middle East for rheumatic problems and backache. The central Asian *F. sumbul* is used as a nerve tonic. *F. jaeschkeana* has recently been investigated as a potential contraceptive. See also *F. gummosa* (following entry).

Caution While safe in adults, asafoetida may be harmful to young babies.

Ferula gummosa syn. *F. galbaniflua*
(Apiaceae)

Galbanum

Description Perennial with a smooth, hollow stem, finely toothed compound leaves, and umbels of small white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to central Asia, galbanum produces a gum that is obtained when stems are cut off and successive slices are made through the roots. Gum wells to the surface and is collected after it has hardened.

Part Used Oleo-gum-resin.

Constituents Galbanum exudate contains a volatile oil, resins, gums, as well as a coumarin (umbelliferone).

History & Folklore Galbanum has been used medicinally for centuries.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Galbanum is a digestive stimulant and antispasmodic, reducing flatulence, cramps, and colic. It is also expectorant. Applied as an ointment, the gum may help heal wounds.

Related Species See asafoetida (*F. assa-foetida*, preceding entry).

Self-help Use Acidity & indigestion, p. 307.

Ficus benghalensis (Moraceae) Banyan Tree

Description Tree growing to 65 ft (20 m) with oval leaves, fig-type fruit, and roots that grow into the ground from branches.

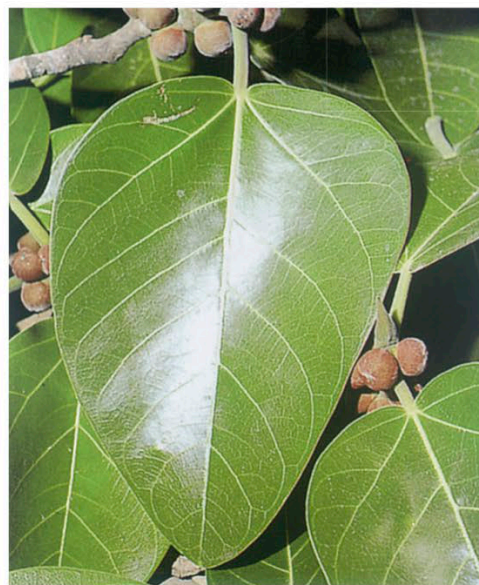
Habitat & Cultivation Growing wild in India and Pakistan, the banyan tree is also cultivated across the Indian subcontinent.

Parts Used Fruit, bark, leaves, latex, aerial roots.

Constituents Banyan tree contains ketones, sterols, ficusin, and bergaptin.

History & Folklore The banyan tree is sacred to Hindus and is frequently found in the proximity of Hindu temples. The god Shiva is often shown sitting peacefully in the shade of a banyan tree. The banyan tree is the national tree of India.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The astringent leaves and bark of the tree are employed to relieve diarrhea and dysentery and to reduce bleeding. As with other *Ficus* species, the latex is applied to



Banyan tree leaves are astringent and are used to tighten mucous membranes.

hemorrhoids, warts, and aching joints. The fruit is laxative and the roots are chewed to prevent gum disease. The bark is used in Ayurvedic medicine for diabetes.

Research In laboratory studies an extract of the leaves was shown to counter diarrhea. Glycosides in banyan have been shown to have an antidiabetic activity, lowering blood-sugar levels.

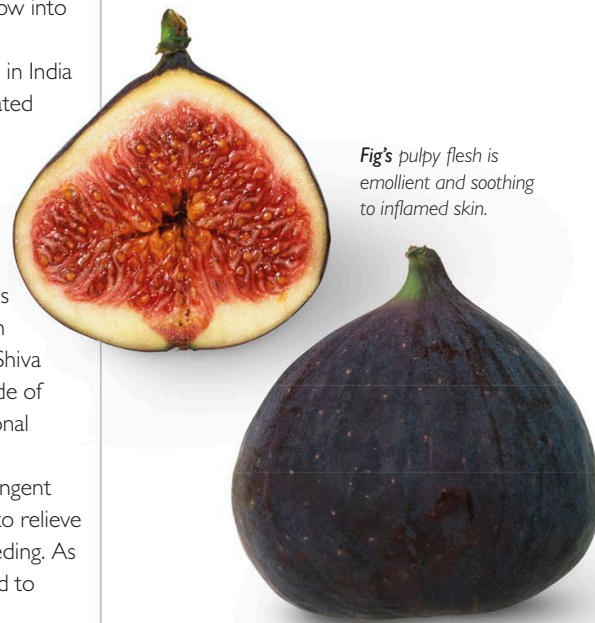
Related Species See fig (*F. carica*, following entry).

Caution The latex is toxic and should not be taken internally.

Ficus carica (Moraceae)

Fig

Description Deciduous tree growing to 13 ft (4 m). Has large leaves and fleshy receptacles that ripen into purple-brown, pear-shaped fruit.



Fig's pulpy flesh is emollient and soothing to inflamed skin.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to western Asia, fig now grows wild and is cultivated in many temperate and subtropical regions. Fruit is harvested in summer.

Parts Used Fruit, latex.

Constituents Figs contain around 50% fruit sugars (mainly glucose), flavonoids, vitamins, and enzymes.

History & Folklore The fig leaf was used by Adam and Eve to hide their nakedness in the Garden of Eden. There are many other references to the plant in the Old Testament, mainly to the sweetness of the fruit and to its use as a medicine. Spartan athletes in Ancient Greece were said to eat figs in order to improve their performance.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The fruit sugars within the fig (especially the dried fruit) have a pronounced but gentle laxative effect; syrup of figs is still a remedy for mild constipation. The fruit's